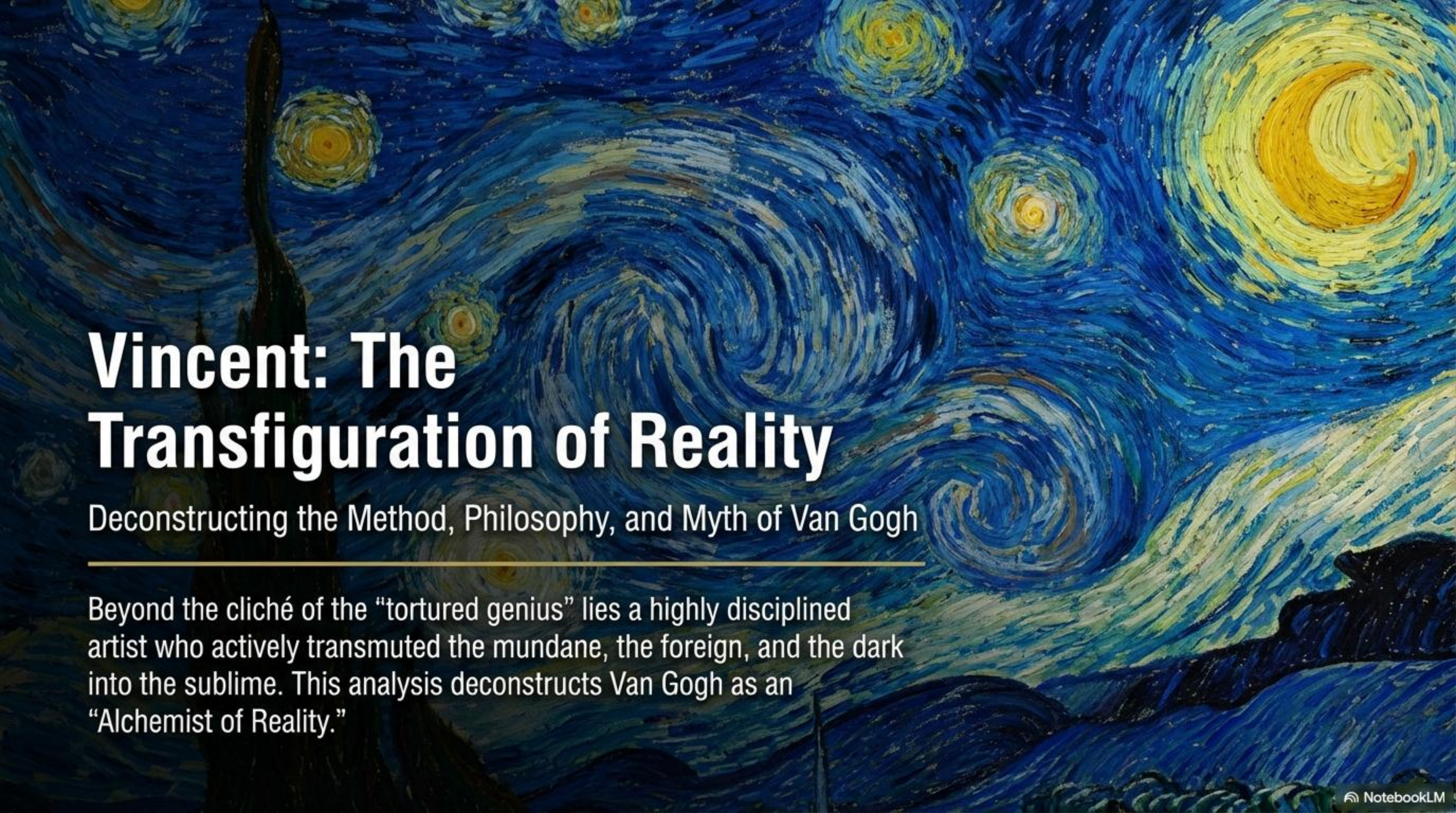


The background of the slide is a reproduction of the painting 'The Starry Night' by Vincent van Gogh. It features a dark, swirling blue sky filled with numerous bright, glowing stars and a large, luminous yellow sun or moon in the upper right. Below the sky, dark, silhouetted hills and a small village with a church spire are visible against the turbulent sea.

Vincent: The Transfiguration of Reality

Deconstructing the Method, Philosophy, and Myth of Van Gogh

Beyond the cliché of the “tortured genius” lies a highly disciplined artist who actively transmuted the mundane, the foreign, and the dark into the sublime. This analysis deconstructs Van Gogh as an “Alchemist of Reality.”

The Alchemy of Ugliness

The Foil Theory: Beauty is often defined in opposition to ugliness, but in reality, they are interpenetrated. Ugliness is merely a distortion of the “normal”.”

The Organic Whole: Van Gogh did not paint ugliness to be morose; he used it to reveal the ‘true color of life.’ By integrating the negative (ugliness/toil) with the positive (artistic form), he creates a “pleasure with bitter taste”—a complex aesthetic freedom that transcends simple elegance.



Source: Zhang Shi-Ying, “Converting Ugliness into Beauty”

“These folks... have tilled the earth themselves with these hands... it speaks of manual labor and—that they have thus honestly earned their food.”

— Vincent van Gogh

A Narrative of Labor

Biography of an Object: These are not just items of clothing; they are a testament to the wearer's journey. The scuffed leather and earthy tones evoke the rugged endurance of the working class.

Technique: Thick, bold brushstrokes (impasto) and a natural palette transform the mundane into a “powerful narrative” of human existence.



Looking East: The Utopia of 'Japon'

The Primitive Utopia:

Van Gogh idealized Japan as a land of simple tradesmen living close to nature. He sought to model his life on this "bonze" (monk) ideal.

Père Tanguy as Symbol:

Tanguy, a socialist art dealer, is depicted in a frontal, symmetrical pose reminiscent of a Buddha. He represents the intersection of Van Gogh's social ideals and his artistic 'Japonisme'.

Visual Context: Recognizable prints including 'The Courtesan Takao' and 'Yoshitsune's Cherry Tree' symbolize the integration of art into daily life. →



Visual Dialectics: The Bridge



Original (Hiroshige):

Characterized by “*peace and tranquility*.”
Muted, atmospheric rain effects.



Interpretation (Van Gogh):

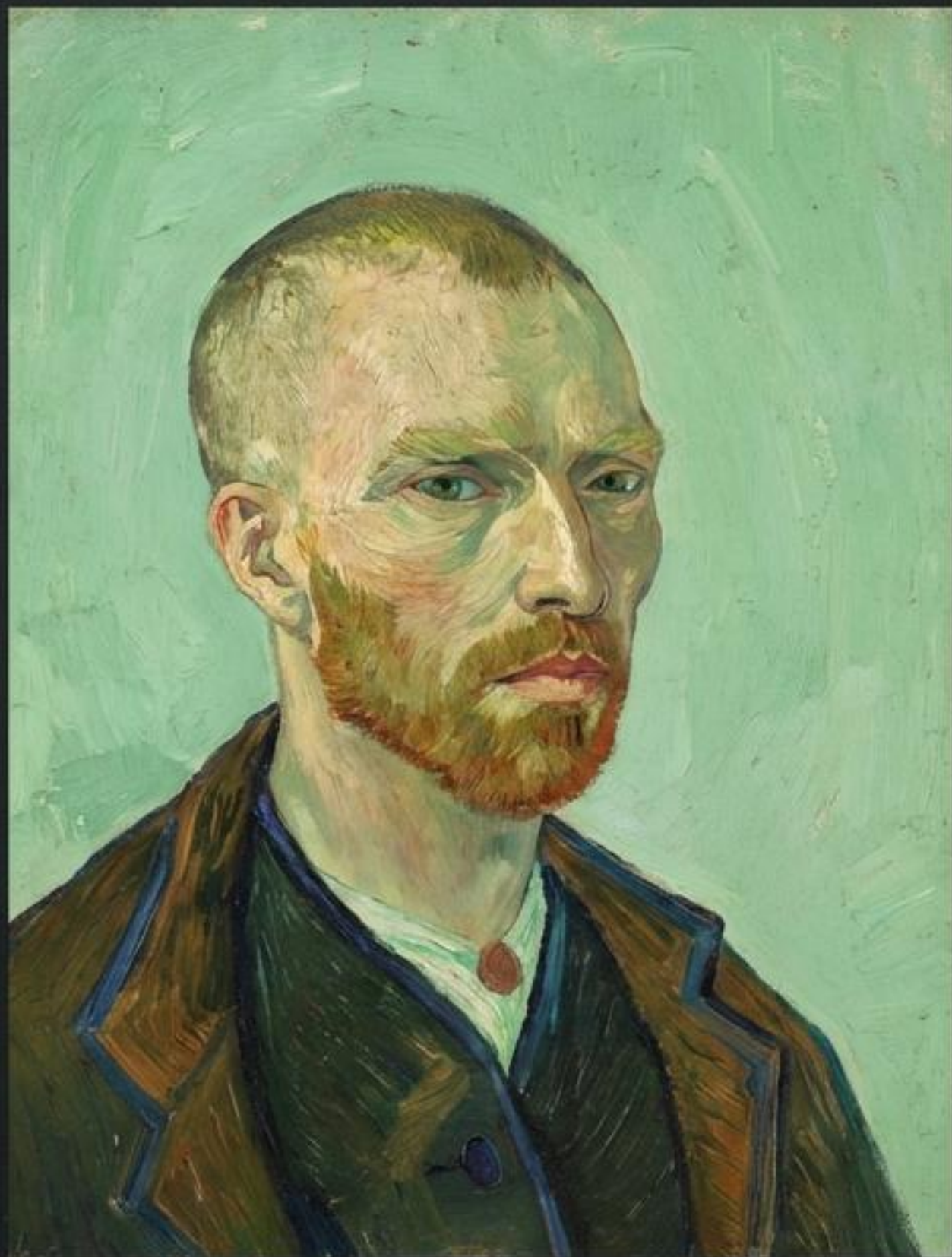
“*Lively and chaotic*” energy. Intensified, vibrant hues replace the soft tones. Note the addition of a custom border filled with kanji-like characters, explicitly framing the image as an exotic object.



Visual Dialectics: The Courtesan

The Grid: Van Gogh used a grid technique to enlarge this figure from a small magazine cover, proving his methodical approach.

Decoded Meaning: The addition of cranes (grue) and frogs (grenouille) in the pond background is a visual pun. Both words were French slang for 'prostitute,' adding a layer of localized, cynical context to the idealized Japanese form.



The Bonze Identity

Physiognomy as Manifesto: Van Gogh altered his own features—slanting the eyes and shaving his head—to resemble a Japanese monk (Bonze).

The Philosophy: A declaration of commitment to a “simple artist’s life,” worshiping the “Eternal Buddha” of art.

Context: Painted for Paul Gauguin, signaling a desire for a brotherhood of artists in a “Studio of the South,” the (sditionally) modeled on utopian Japanese communal life.



Saint-Rémy: Constraint & Creativity

The Context: Van Gogh entered the asylum voluntarily on May 8, 1889.

The Constraint: Confined to the premises, he was cut off from models and street scenes.

The Shift: Limitation forced a pivot. Unable to paint *sujet* (complex subjects), he became obsessed with *effet* (weather, light, and the view from his window).



Deconstructing *The Starry Night* (June 1889)

The Cypress:
A dark, flamelike
form representing
death and mourning.

The Village:
An imaginative
construction based on
memory, not visible
from his window.



The Morning Star:
Venus, observed
looking "very big"
at dawn.

Key Insight: A composite of direct observation and artistic invention, proving cognitive control over the composition.

The Science of Night

The Challenge: Painting *en plein air* at night was a technical anomaly. Van Gogh was obsessed with capturing the specific colors of darkness.

Gas vs. Star: He contrasted the harsh, gold/yellow artificial gas light of the town against the natural teal, violet, and green of the starlight.

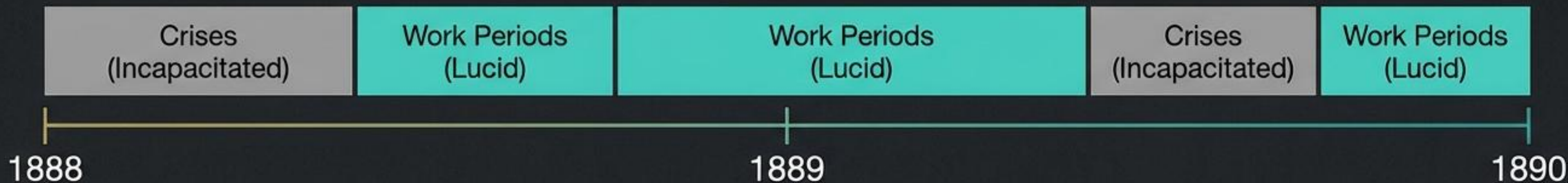
Constellation Accuracy: The painting features the Great Bear (Ursa Major) sparkling green and pink—scientifically observed but artistically enhanced.



The 'Tortured Genius' Fallacy

The Reality: Van Gogh did not paint *during* his psychotic episodes; he was incapacitated. He painted *between* them.

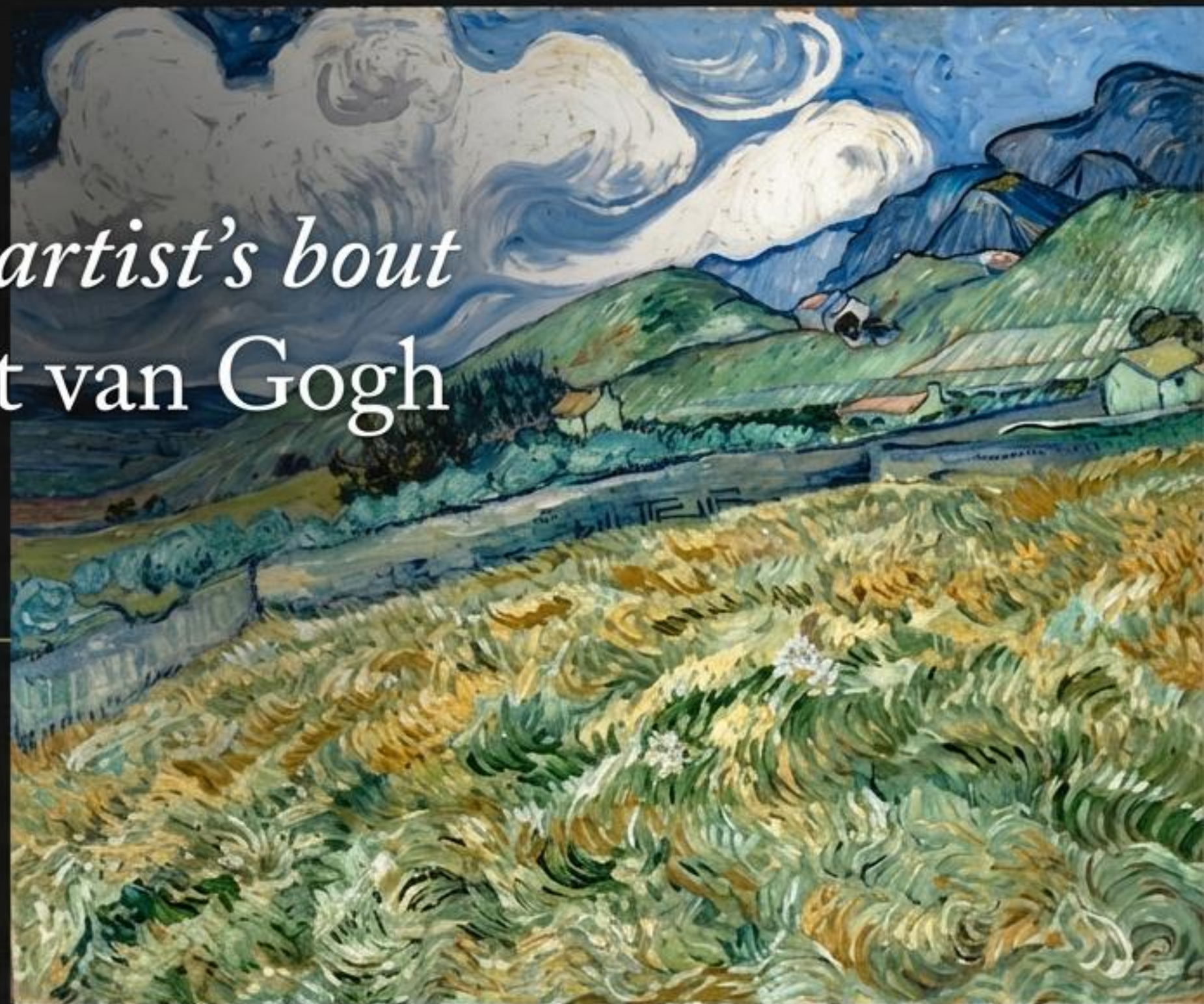
Agency: He viewed his illness as a hindrance to be overcome, not a muse to be indulged.



“I have just had a simple artist’s bout of craziness.” — Vincent van Gogh

Art as Consolation

For Van Gogh, painting offered ‘consolation’ — a cathartic sense of restoration and harmony. In the isolation of the asylum, the act of observing and recording nature was his primary tether to reality.



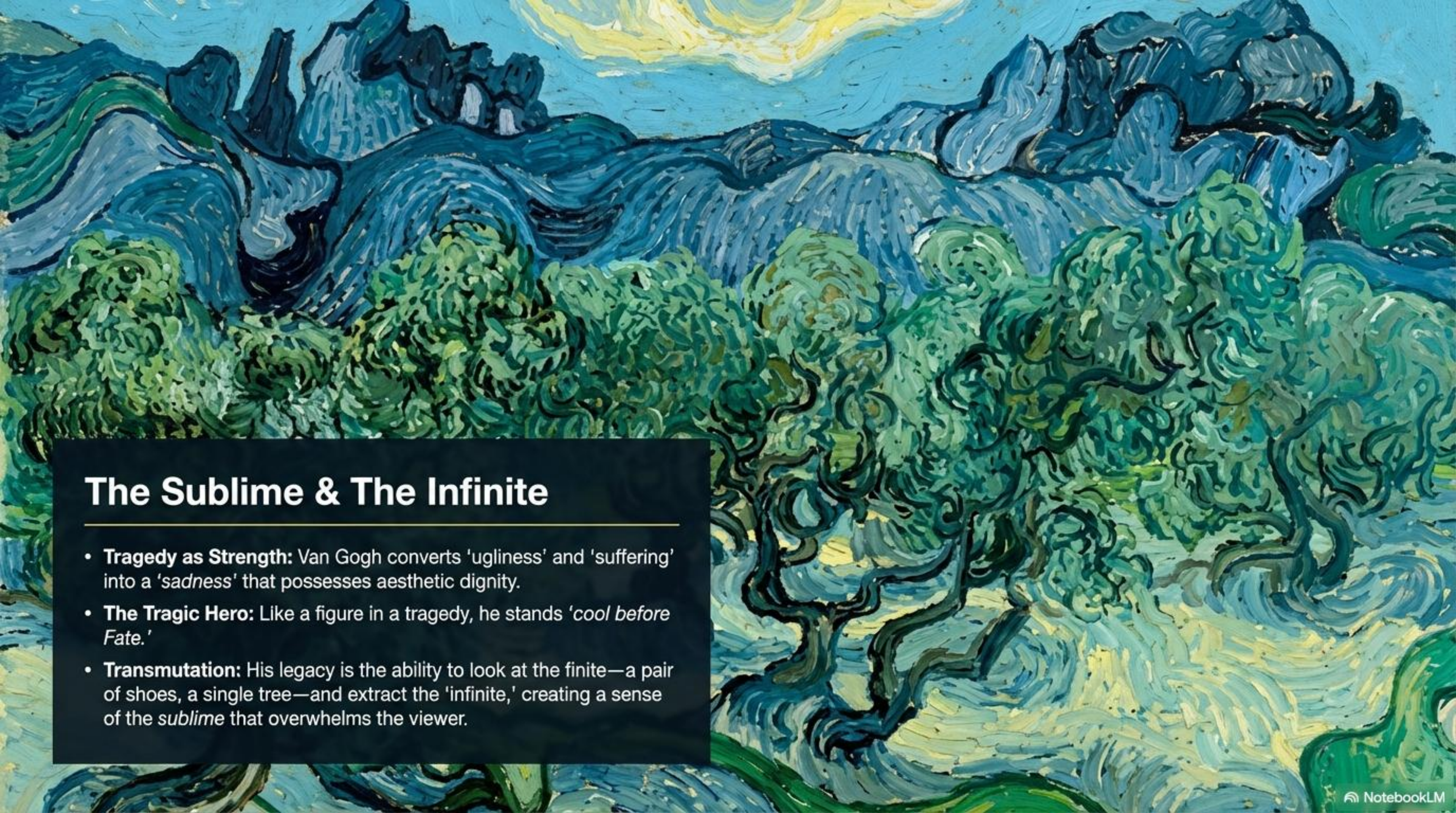
The Collapse of the Studio

The Catalyst: The breakdown in late 1888 was the result of exhaustion, alcohol, and the crushing disappointment of his failed collaboration with Paul Gauguin.

The Dream: He had hoped to build a “Studio of the South.” When Gauguin prepared to leave, the dream collapsed.

The Reality: The self-mutilation was a “human tragedy,” not an artistic statement. It marked the beginning of a cycle of crises that he fought bravely until the end.

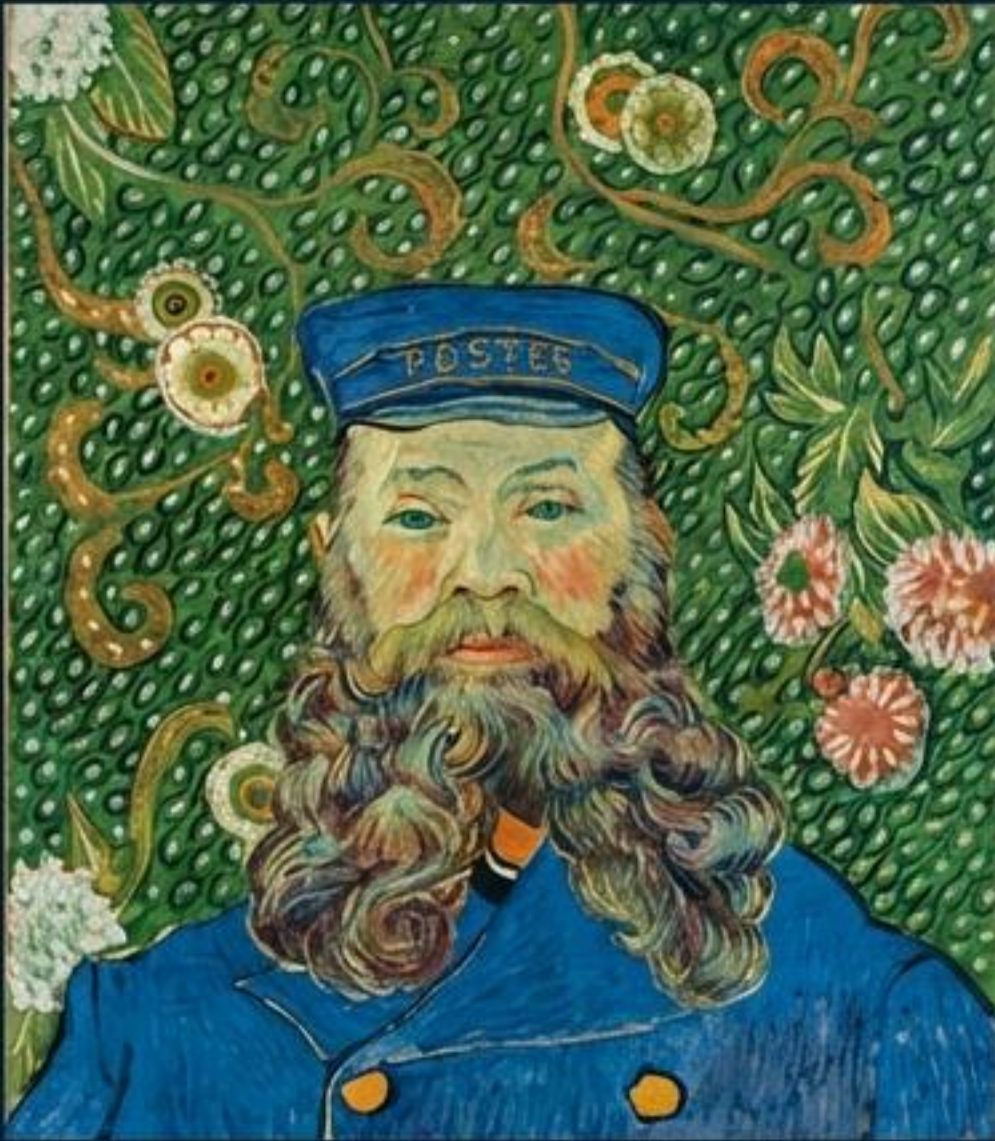




The Sublime & The Infinite

- **Tragedy as Strength:** Van Gogh converts 'ugliness' and 'suffering' into a 'sadness' that possesses aesthetic dignity.
- **The Tragic Hero:** Like a figure in a tragedy, he stands '*cool before Fate.*'
- **Transmutation:** His legacy is the ability to look at the finite—a pair of shoes, a single tree—and extract the 'infinite,' creating a sense of the *sublime* that overwhelms the viewer.

The Alchemist's Legacy



- **Reality:** Finding the biography in the humble object.
- **The East:** Adopting the disciplined 'bonze' identity to restructure his vision.
- **Consolation:** Using art as a shield against the darkness.



“It was not because of his illness that he was such a great artist but, despite his illness, he could still be this great artist.”